Document maintenance guide

A practical reference for policies guides and manuals

ORIGINAL PORTFOLIO SAMPLE

Created by OK Agency to demonstrate an editable document structure and a matching reading copy. Use this guide when updating a shared document so readers can find the right section and work from the current version.

1 Keep the structure consistent

1.1 Use styles for every heading

Apply Heading 1 to each main section and Heading 2 to its subsections. Keep the levels in order. The heading numbers belong to one multilevel list, so a new section can be inserted without manually renumbering the document.

Write short headings that describe the task or subject. Check the Navigation Pane after adding or moving a section. It should show a clear outline without body text appearing as a heading.

1.2 Maintain readable body text

Use the Normal style for ordinary paragraphs. Let the style control font, line spacing and the space after each paragraph. Avoid repeated blank paragraphs or spaces used to position text; they make later edits harder to manage.

Keep each paragraph focused on one action or idea. When instructions change, check nearby references and examples as well as the edited sentence. A small wording correction should not alter the intended meaning.

1.3 Handle page breaks deliberately

Keep headings with the text that follows them. Use a page break only when the next section needs to begin on a new page. After a substantial edit, check the final line of each page for isolated words or an unexpected gap.

Working rule: change the relevant style once when a document-wide adjustment is needed. Use direct formatting only for a deliberate exception, such as a short emphasis within a paragraph.

2 Review and release the update

2.1 Record meaningful changes

Keep a brief change record near the end of the document. Describe what changed and where the reader can find it. Update the version label when releasing a revised copy; do not use the file modification date as the only version record.

The example below records the creation of this sample. In a working document, add a row for each released revision and retain earlier entries that help readers understand the document history.

Version	Location	Change
1.0	Whole guide	Original portfolio sample created with numbered headings and a revision record.

2.2 Check the editable copy

Read the revised sections in context. Confirm that heading numbers progress correctly and that table text fits within its cells. Check the header, footer and page numbers, then remove comments or tracked changes that are not intended for the released version.

Save the editable master in the agreed location. Give the reading copy the same base filename and version so the two files can be matched without opening them. Keep a previous release when a rollback may be useful.

2.3 Compare the exported reading copy

Export a PDF from the final editable master. Open both files and compare every page, including the first and last lines, heading numbers and table rows. Confirm that text can be selected and that the document opens with the expected fonts.

Before sharing, check the title, version and page count. Use descriptive link text for any references and test the destination. Release the Word and PDF copies together after the final review.

Next update: start from the editable master, make the smallest clear change and repeat the review above.